

Session 28: Narrative Analogy: Jacob and Genesis 3

Key Takeaways

- Throughout the entire storyline of the Hebrew Bible, there will be snake-people and humanity-people, and they are going to be at enmity with one another in narrative after narrative.
- In the Hebrew Bible narratives, people can switch back and forth between being a seed of the woman and a seed of the snake. Even the people God calls to be his blessing to the world can become the seed of the snake.
- The birth of the nation of Israel is depicted as the birth of snake seed. The whole drama of the Jacob story is how God is going to turn Jacob (the snake-like deceiver) into a human.

Genesis 16 Recalls Earlier Narratives

Genesis 16	Genesis 3 and 6
16:1-2a: Now, Sarai, Abram's wife had borne him no children, and she had an Egyptian slave whose name was Hagar. And Sarai said to Abram, "Look, Yahweh has prevented me from giving birth. Please go in to my slave; maybe I can be built up (בנה) through her."	2:21-22: And Yahweh God took from one of the sides of the human ... and he built (בנה) the side into a woman. 3:17: Because you listened to the voice of your wife (שמע + לקול)
16:2b: And Abram listened to the voice of Sarai (שמע + לקול)	
16:3-4: and Sarai took (ותתן) Hagar ... and she gave (ותתן) her to Abram her husband (אִישָׁהּ) as a wife (לְאִשָּׁה). ... And he went into her.	6:2-4: And the sons of God saw (ראה) the daughters of humanity, that they were good, and they took (לקח) for themselves wives (נָשִׁים) ... when they went into (יבאו + אל) the daughters of humanity, and they gave birth (ילד). 3:6: and the woman (אִשָּׁה) ... took (ותקח) the fruit ... and she gave (ותתן) also to her husband (לְאִישָׁהּ), and he ate.
Genesis 16 Recalls Earlier Narratives. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Introduction to the Hebrew Bible (2019).	

Genesis 16	Genesis 3 and 6
16:4: and she [Hagar] saw that (ותרא כי) she was pregnant, and her master was cursed in her eyes (בעיניה). Birth becomes curse to Sarai instead of blessing 16:6: Abram said to Sarai, "Behold, your slave is in your hand, do to her what is good (טוב) in your eyes (בעיניך)."	3:6: And the woman saw that (ותרא כי) the tree was good (טוב) for food, and desirable to the eyes (לענים) "cursed is the ground because of you"
16:8: And [the angel] said to Hagar ... "From where (אי מזה) have you come, and to where do you go?"	3:9: "And Yahweh God called to the human and said, "Where are you (איכה)?"
16:10: And the angel of Yahweh said to her [Hagar]: "I will greatly multiply (הרבה ארבה) your seed ... You are pregnant (הרה), will give birth (ילד) to a son."	3:16: To the woman he said, "I will greatly multiply (הריונד) your grief and pregnancy (הרבה ארבה), and in grief you will give birth (ילד)"
<i>Genesis 16 Recalls Earlier Narratives.</i> Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Introduction to the Hebrew Bible (2019).	

In this analogy, Abram and Sarai’s actions are set on analogy to both Genesis 6:1-4 and 3:1-9, and characters become linked to counterparts in earlier stories through repeated words and phrases.

- Hagar is linked to the tree of knowing good and bad and to the daughters of humanity.
- Sarai is linked to Eve and to the rebel sons of God.
- Abram is linked to Adam.

Genesis 25 and 27, and Genesis 3

Jacob the Snake in Genesis 25

20 and **Isaac was a son of forty years**

a when he took Rebekah,

b the daughter of Bethuel the Aramean of Paddan-aram,
b' the sister of Lavan the Aramean,

a' to be his wife.

a 21 And Isaac petitioned Yahweh
b on behalf of his wife, because she was barren;
a' and Yahweh was petitioned by him

^a b' and Rebekah his wife conceived.

22 And they struck one another, the sons within her,
and she said, "If it is so, why then am I?"
And she went to inquire of Yahweh.

23 And Yahweh said to her,

a "Two nations are in your womb;
a' and two peoples will be separated from your body;
b and one people shall be stronger than the other;
b' and the older shall serve the younger."

24 And when her days were fulfilled to give birth,
behold, there were twins within her womb.

a 25 And the first came out red (אדום),
b all over like a hairy garment (שער)
c and they named him Esau (עשו).
a' 26 And afterward his brother came out
b' and his hand was grabbing the heel (עקב) of Esau,
c' and he called his name Yaaqov (יעקב);

and Isaac was a son of sixty years

when she gave birth to them.

Genesis 25:20-26. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Introduction to the Hebrew Bible (2019).

There is only one other text in the Hebrew Bible that describes one character doing something to the "heel" (עקב) of another character.

Genesis 3:14-15 Instructor's Translation

14 And Yahweh God said to the snake ...

15 "And I will put enmity
between you and the woman,
and between your seed and her seed;
he shall strike you on the head,
and you shall strike him on the heel (עקב)."

The very next narrative about Jacob shows him deceiving his brother with food in order to usurp his place as the firstborn.

Rebekah and Jacob Deceive Isaac and Esau in Genesis 27

27:1-5 Isaac Instructs Esau To Prepare Food To Receive the Blessing

27:1 And Isaac called for Esau his older son ...

27:6-17 Rebekah Instructs Yaaqov To Prepare Food To Steal Esau's Blessing

5-6 And Rebekah heard when Isaac spoke (בדבר) to Esau his son ...
and she said to Yaaqov her son, "Behold ..."

8 "And now, my son, listen to my voice ... go now to the flock and take for me ..."

15 She took the clothes of Esau her older son ... and clothed Yaaqov her younger son

27:18-29 Yaaqov Deceives His Father Isaac To Steal the Blessing

18-19 And he went to his father, and he said, "Who are you my son?"

"I am Esau your firstborn ... arise and eat ... so that you may bless me!"

27:27-29 Poem of Blessing

27-29 "See, the smell of my son ..."

27:30-40 Esau Begs His Father Isaac To Give Him a Blessing

31-32 And he went to his father, and said, "Let my father arise and eat so that you may bless me!"
"Who are you my son?" "I am Esau your firstborn."

27:39-40 Poem of Non-Blessing

39-40 "Behold, away from the fertility of the earth shall be your dwelling ..."

27:41-45 Rebekah Instructs Yaaqov To Flee to Paddan Aram

27:42 And it was reported to Rebekah the words (דבר) of Esau her older son
and she sent and called to Yaaqov her smaller son and said, "Behold ..."

27:43 "And now, my son, listen to my voice, arise and flee for yourself"

27:46-28:5 Isaac Blesses and Instructs Yaaqov To Go to Aram to Get Married

28:1 And Isaac called for Yaaqov ...

Narrative Analogies Between Genesis 27 and Genesis 1-3

Genesis 27	Genesis 1-3
27:1: And [Isaac’s] eyes were weak/dim to be seeing	3:7: The humans’ eyes are “opened” because of the forbidden food.
27:4, 7: Isaac requests that Esau bring fresh game “that I may eat (אכל), on which account (בעבור) my being will bless you (ברך) before I die (מות)”	3:6: and she took and she ate (אכל) 3:17: “cursed (ארורה) is the ground on account of you (בעבורך)”
27:8: “And now my son, listen to my voice (שמע בקול) to what I am commanding (צוה) you.”	3:17: And to the man he said, “Because you have listened to the voice (שמע + בקול) of your wife and ate of the tree that I commanded (צוה) you ...”
27:9: “Go now to the flock and take (לקח) for me two young goats, good ones (טוב) ... that he may eat (אכל) and bless (ברך) you before his death (מות)”	3:6: And she took (לקח) from its fruit and she ate (אכל)
27:12-13: “Perhaps I will be in his eyes (עיניו) like one who makes a mockery, and I will bring upon myself a curse and not a blessing (קללה ולא ברכה).” And she said, “May your curse (קללה) be upon me my son. Just listen to my voice (שמע בקול), and go and take (לקח) for me.”	3:17: And to the man he said, “Because you have listened to the voice (שמע + בקול) of your wife and ate of the tree that I commanded (צוה) you ... cursed (ארורה) is the ground on account of you.”
27:14-15: And he went and he took (ויקח) and he brought to his mother ... And she took (ותקח) the clothes of Esau her son, the bigger one, the desirable ones (החמדת) which were with her	3:6: And the woman saw that the tree was good for eating, and desirable (תאוה) to the eyes, and desirable (נחמד) for becoming wise, and she took (לקח)
27:15: And she clothed (ותלבש) Jacob her son, the little one, and with the skins (ערת) of the goats she clothed (והלבישה) over his hands	3:21: And God made for the man and his wife garments of skin (עור) and he clothed them (וילבשם)
Analogies Between Genesis 27 and Genesis 1-3. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Introduction to the Hebrew Bible (2019).	

Genesis 27	Genesis 1-3
27:17: And she gave (ותתן) the tasty foods and the bread which she made into the hand of Jacob her son.	3:6: and she took from its fruit and she ate and she gave (ותתן) to her husband and he ate.
27:33: "Who then is the one who hunted game and brought it to me and I ate from all (ואכל מכל) ...?"	2:16: "From every/all (מכל) tree in the garden you may eat (תאכל)"; cf. also 3:1-2
27:35-36: "Your brother came in deceit (במרמה), and he took (ויקח) your blessing." And [Esau] said, "Isn't he rightly called heel/deceiver (יעקב), for he heeled/deceived (עקב) me two times! He took (לקח) my birthright (בכרה), and he took (לקח) my blessing (ברכה)."	3:13: And she said, "The snake deceived me (נשא) and I ate"
27:43: "And now my son, listen to my voice (שמע בקול)"	3:17: "Because you have listened to the voice (שמע + בקול) of your wife"
27:44-45: "Dwell [in Aram] for a few days, until ... he forgets that which you have done to him (את אשר עשית לו)"	3:13: And God said to the woman, "What is this you have done (מה זאת עשית)?" 3:14: And God said to the snake, "Because you have done this thing (כי עשית זאת)"
28:3: "May El Shaddai bless you and make your fruitful and multiply	1:28: And God blessed them and said, "Be fruitful and multiply"
Analogies Between Genesis 27 and Genesis 1-3. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Introduction to the Hebrew Bible (2019).	

Rachel Replays Sarah's/Eve's Sin in Genesis 30-31

Rachel and Bilhah	Sarah and Hagar: Genesis 16
Genesis 3:6: And the woman (האשה) saw (ותרא) that the tree was good for eating ... and she took (ותקח) from its fruit and she ate and she gave (ותתן) also to her husband (איש) with her and he ate.	
Genesis 3:17: And God said to the man, "Because you have listened to the voice (שמע + לקול) of your	
Rachel Replays Sarah and Eve. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Introduction to the Hebrew Bible (2019).	

Rachel and Bilhah	Sarah and Hagar: Genesis 16
wife ...”	
30:1: And Rachel saw (ותרא) that she had not given birth for Jacob and she was jealous of her sister	Gen 16:1: And Sarai ... had not given birth for Abram
30:2: And Jacob said, “Am I in the place of God who has withheld from you the fruit of the womb?” 30:3: “Behold (הנה), my maid-slave (אמתי) Bilhah, go into her and she will give birth upon my knees, and I will be built up, me too, from her (בנה + מן).”	16:2: And Sarai said ... “Behold (הנה), Yahweh has bound me from giving birth. Please go into my slave (שפחה). Perhaps I can be built up from her (בנה + מן).” And Abraham listened to her voice (שמע + בקול).
30:4: And she gave to him (ותתן לו) Bilhah her slave (שפחה) as a wife (לאשה) and he went into her	16:3: And Sarai took ... her slave (שפחה) ... and she gave her to (–ותתן ל) Abram ... as a wife (לאשה), and he went into her
30:5: And [Bilhah] became pregnant	16:4: And [Hagar] became pregnant and when she saw (ותרא) she was pregnant, her mistress was cursed in her eyes.
30:6: And Rachel said, “God has judged for me and also he has listened to my voice (שמע + בקול)”	16:11: “Behold you are pregnant, and you will bear a son and call his name ‘ Yishma el’ (ישמעאל) for Yahweh has listened (שמע) to your suffering.”
<i>Rachel Replays Sarah and Eve.</i> Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Introduction to the Hebrew Bible (2019).	

Rachel’s actions with Jacob are both an intensified replay of Sarah’s actions with Abraham and a contrast with Rebekah from Genesis 25:21.

- Sarah is barren, so she schemes her own way to produce the promised seed, and she accuses Abraham when the plan doesn’t work.
- Rebekah is barren, but Isaac intercedes for her and Yahweh restores fertility to her womb.
- Rachel is barren, accuses her husband for not giving her sons, and then schemes her own way (identical to Sarah’s) to produce seed.

The Pattern of the Late-Comer

This story makes it clear that the book of Genesis is arranged as a sequence of generations feuding over the possession of abundance, blessing, and royal power.

Divinely Chosen Late-Comer	Non-Chosen Early-Comer
Adam & Eve	Beast of the field (= snake)
Abel/Seth	Cain
Shem	Japheth (also Ham the younger)
Abram	Nahor, Haran
Isaac	Ishmael
Jacob	Esau
Joseph	The brothers
Judah	Reuben, Simeon, Levi
<i>Late-comer Pattern.</i> Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Introduction to the Hebrew Bible (2019).	

Later Iterations of the Genesis 3 Pattern

Joshua 6-7: Achan's Sin at Jericho

Achan's sin at Jericho reiterates the Genesis 3 pattern.

- [Joshua 6](#) describes Israel's victory at Jericho. They march for six days, and on the seventh day they march seven times and shout. This reflects Genesis 1, with six days of work plus the seventh day of rest.
- [Joshua 6:18-19](#): Joshua says to the people, "Only watch yourselves, don't take any of the dedicated plunder, lest you take from the dedicated plunder and place it in the camp of Israel ... and bring trouble (עֲכָר) to it. All the silver and gold and articles (כִּלְיִם) of bronze and iron are holy to Yahweh."
- [Joshua 7:1](#): "But the sons of Israel committed treachery with the dedicated plunder, and Achan, the son of Carmi, son of Zabdi, son of Zerah, of the tribe of Judah, he took from the dedicated plunder."
- [Joshua 7:11](#): "Israel has sinned, and they have broken my covenant which I commanded them, and also they have taken from the dedicated things and stolen, and also they have lied and placed it in their baggage (lit. "articles" בְּכֵלֵיהֶם)."
- [Joshua 7:19-21](#): "And Joshua said to Achan, '... Tell me please, what have you done? Don't conceal it from me.' And Achan answered Joshua and said, 'Truly, I have sinned against Yahweh God of Israel. Such and such have I done: I saw (רָאָה) among the plunder a cloak of Shinar (אֹדֶרֶת שִׁנְעָר), a good one (טוֹב), and two hundred shekels of silver ... and I desired them (חָמַד), and I took them (לָקַח) and look, they are hidden in the ground in the middle of my tent, and the silver is under it.'"

2 Samuel 11: David and Bathsheba

2 Samuel 11:2-4 Instructor's Translation

And it came about at the time of evening, that David arose from his bed and walked about on the roof of the house of the king, and **he saw a woman bathing on the roof**, and the woman was **good of sight**, very. And David sent and he inquired about the woman ... and he sent messengers and **he took her** and he went into her ...

The Genesis 3 pattern of see and take is a core element of the biblical narrative and it repeats in various forms throughout the Hebrew Bible.

Recommended Resources: Narrative Analogy

- Robert Alter, [*The Art of the Biblical Narrative*](#), ch. 3
- Yair Zakovitch, [“Through the Looking Glass: Reflection/ Inversions of Genesis Stories in the Bible,” pp. 139-152](#)
- Brian Sigmon, [“Between Eden and Egypt: Echoes of the Garden Narrative in the Story of Joseph and His Brothers”](#)
- Moshe Garsiel, [The First Book of Samuel: A Literary Study of Comparative Structures, Analogies, and Parallels](#)
- Jonathan Grossman, [“Dynamic Analogies in Esther,” pp. 394-414](#)
- Joshua Berman, [Narrative Analogy in the Hebrew Bible](#)

Narrative Analogy and Inner-Biblical Hyperlinks

	Citation	Allusion	Echo
Level of Communication	Explicit	Implicit	Subtle
Reader’s Comprehension	Assumed	Expected	Hoped for
Technique	Quotation of source text	Key words from source text	Key words, images, themes from source text
	Analogy		
Narrative Analogy and Inner-Biblical Hyperlinks. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Introduction to the Hebrew Bible (2019).			

Citation	Allusion	Echo
	Parallel design patterns of character, plot, setting, key words Indicating an intended analogy between whole storylines	
<i>Narrative Analogy and Inner-Biblical Hyperlinks.</i> Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Introduction to the Hebrew Bible (2019).		

Citation: An explicitly marked quotation from an earlier biblical text. Example: Joshua 8:30-35 cross-references and quotes Deuteronomy 27:4-6.

Allusion: A non-explicit form of reference to an another text marked by multiple conspicuous words or images from a known source text. In this case, the full meaning of the text will be diminished if the reader fails to recognize the implied reference to the earlier text. Example: Numbers 14:18-19 alludes back to Exodus 34:6-7.

Echo: A more subtle technique that may involve the inclusion of a single phrase, word, or image that alerts the reader to a reference to an another text. The text is fully intelligible to readers who don't recognize the echo, but those who do will experience a "surplus of significance" beyond the face value meaning of the text. Example: The Genesis 3 design pattern described above includes echoes.

In his article, "Identifying Inner-Biblical Allusions," Jeffrey Leonard gives four criteria for identifying intertextual allusions and hyperlinks (Leonard, 2008).

1. Clusters of shared words or phrases
2. Shared language consisting of unique vocabulary
3. Shared language within thematically similar contexts
4. Shared language between units that are united by other literary strategies (similar plot, themes, settings)

Literary Echoes and a Modern Example

"Metalepsis [is] the literary technique of citing or echoing a small bit of a precursor text in such a way that the reader can grasp the significance of the echo only by recalling or recovering the original context of the echo and reading the two texts in fruitful juxtaposition. The effect of such an intertextual linkage lies in the unstated or suppressed points of correspondence between the two texts ... creating a 'cave of resonant signification.'"

Hays, Richard B. (2017). [*Echoes of Scripture in the Gospels*](#). Baylor University Press. 10-11.

On the night of Barack Obama's presidential election victory in 2008, he declared that American citizens could "put their hands on the arc of history and bend it once more toward the hope of a better day." This phrase was an allusion to a famous line of a speech of Martin Luther King Jr., but the new context also signaled a series of adaptations to the new rhetorical setting.

Barack Obama	Martin Luther King Jr.
“Tonight begins our chance to put our hands on the arc of history and bend it once more toward the hope of a better day.” <i>A word of exhortation to recommit one’s energies to building a better world, emphasizing the necessity of human agency to enact change.</i>	“The arc of the moral universe is long, but it bends towards justice.” <i>A word of assurance that the civil rights struggle was governed by a larger providential purpose that would prevail.</i>
“We may not get there in one year or even in one term, but America, I promise you, we as a people will get there.” <i>Obama depicts himself as Joshua the successor to Moses (= King), who will play his part in leading America to the next step towards the promised land.</i>	“I’ve seen the promised land. I may not get there with you.” <i>King was depicting himself as a Moses participating in a new exodus, passing the baton to Joshua (= his listeners).</i>
<i>Obama Speech MLK Allusions. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Introduction to the Hebrew Bible (2019).</i>	

This is precisely the kind of explicit and more subtle use of a “cultural encyclopedia” that happens in all forms of communication, especially between people steeped in traditional literature.

Reflection Question

In the birth story of Jacob and Esau in Genesis 25, in what way is Jacob like the snake from Genesis 3? What tension does this create for the overall storyline?